TOPIC 01 · EXCEL FUNDAMENTALS WITH COPILOT
LAB 1 THEME · DATA PREP & DATA QUALITY

Lab 1 — Explore and Question Recruitment Pipeline Data

Maps to	LO1: confirm Copilot access and use the Chat only, Plan and Allow editing modes to prepare, check, highlight, sort and filter recruitment pipeline data
Duration	35 minutes
Tools	Excel for Microsoft 365 (desktop) · Copilot (Chat only, Plan, Allow editing, model picker) · BrightPath_Candidate_Pipeline.xlsx
Mock data	data/BrightPath_Candidate_Pipeline.xlsx
Course	Microsoft 365 Copilot for Excel (C34) · v3.1
Prompts	https://tertiarycourses.github.io/C34-Microsoft-365-Copilot-for-Excel/prompts/#lab-1

Goal

Turn a raw candidate-pipeline export into a named Excel table, find its data-quality issues with Copilot, and answer pipeline questions with checked numbers.

What You Will Do

You are a talent analyst at BrightPath Talent Solutions, a fictional Singapore recruitment and staffing firm. You will meet Copilot's three modes on a real task: Allow editing turns the H1 2026 pipeline export into a named table, Chat only describes it without touching the sheet, and Plan shows you its steps before it fixes duplicate IDs and inconsistent Source labels. You will then answer pipeline questions, compare two AI models on the same question, and build a highlighted, sorted and filtered review view. Every number is checked with a formula.

What You Will Build

BrightPath_Candidate_Pipeline.xlsx in your work-c34 folder with table tblApplications, a Source_Clean column, duplicate IDs highlighted, Hired rows highlighted, a verified source-by-hires answer and a filled Prompt_Log

Prerequisites

- A Microsoft 365 account with Copilot in Excel enabled, signed in to Excel for Microsoft 365 (desktop).
- A folder named work-c34 on your computer for your working copies.
- This lab folder downloaded, including data/BrightPath_Candidate_Pipeline.xlsx.

Data note

Use only the supplied fictional BrightPath data or information you are authorised to process. Do not paste credentials, confidential business material or real employees' personal data into Copilot, rules or skills.

Steps

Step 1. Copy BrightPath_Candidate_Pipeline.xlsx from this lab's data folder into a work-c34 folder on your computer and open it in Excel for Microsoft 365 (desktop). Work on this local copy - no OneDrive upload is needed. Check that Formulas > Calculation Options is Automatic, then open Copilot from the Copilot button on the Home tab or the floating Copilot icon at the bottom right. Read the About_This_Data sheet before you prompt.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
Required state:
File : work-c34/BrightPath_Candidate_Pipeline.xlsx (local copy)
Calculation Options : Automatic
Sheets : About_This_Data | Applications | Prompt_Log
```

Step 2. Open Copilot and find the mode menu above the prompt box: Chat only (answers, no changes), Plan (shows its steps first) and Allow editing (makes the changes). Choose Allow editing and ask Copilot to turn the Applications data into a named table. Its reply must confirm tblApplications, 13 columns and 242 data rows. Select Done to keep the change, or Undo to reverse it. If Excel offers 'Clean data with Copilot', select Dismiss for now - you will use it in Lab 4.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ALLOW EDITING:
Format the data on the Applications sheet (from A1 to the last row and column) as an Excel
table with headers. Name the table tblApplications. Do not change, sort or delete any values.
Then tell me the table name, the number of columns and the number of data rows.
```

Step 3. Switch to Chat only (no workbook changes). Paste the prompt below. Copilot's row count must match the 242 rows it reported in Step 2. If Copilot already points out Source labels such as 'Linked In' or 'JobStreet ' (trailing space), note them - Step 4 checks and fixes them. You will log every prompt in Step 7.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
GOAL: Describe this candidate pipeline before I analyse it.
CONTEXT: BrightPath recruitment desk, H1 2026. One row should be one application.
DATA: Use only tblApplications.
CONSTRAINTS: Do not change the workbook.
OUTPUT: What a row represents, each column with its data type, the number of rows, the
Applied_Date range and the distinct values of Stage and Source.
REVIEW: Tell me how you counted the rows.
```

Step 4. Still in Chat only, ask Copilot to check data quality. It should report 2 repeated Application_IDs and Source values that are not in the canonical list on About_This_Data. Then switch to Plan mode and send the two changes: Copilot first shows its plan - read it, approve it, then select Done. Orange means 'this ID appears more than once': each duplicate ID is coloured in both places it occurs, so you see one orange cell near the top of the table and its twin further down (press Ctrl+End to jump to the last rows). Check that no row was deleted - the table must still have 242 rows.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
CHAT ONLY:
Check tblApplications for data-quality issues. List any Application_ID that appears more than
once, and any Source value that is not exactly one of: LinkedIn, JobStreet, MyCareersFuture,
Referral, BrightPath Website, Job Fair, Talent Database. Give the count of each issue. Do not
change anything.

PLAN MODE:
1) Highlight Application_ID cells that appear more than once in tblApplications with an orange
fill.
2) Add a column Source_Clean to tblApplications that trims spaces from Source and changes
'Linked In' to 'LinkedIn'. Do not delete or edit any existing values.

FOLLOW-UP: For each duplicated Application_ID, give the row numbers of both copies and say
whether the two rows are identical.
```

```
FOLLOW-UP: Highlight the Source cells in tblApplications where Source_Clean is different from
Source with a yellow fill. Tell me how many cells you highlighted and list their
Application_IDs.

FOLLOW-UP: List the distinct Source_Clean values with a count of each. Confirm there is no
'Linked In' and no value with a trailing space, and that tblApplications still has 242 rows.
```

Step 5. Ask Copilot a direct question about which sources produce hires, then ask Copilot (Allow editing) to add the two check formulas to a Checks sheet. Duplicate rows are Rejected applications, so they do not change the hire counts. Finally, open the model picker at the top of the pane (Auto by default), choose a different model, select New chat and ask the same question again. Both answers must match the Checks formulas - if a model disagrees, the formula wins.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
PROMPT (Chat only):
Using tblApplications, count applications and hires (Stage = "Hired") by Source_Clean.
Show a table sorted by hires, highest first, with hire rate = hires / applications.

CHECK (Allow editing):
On a sheet named Checks (create it if needed), add these formulas with a label beside each,
then tell me the results:
=COUNTIFS(tblApplications[Stage],"Hired")
=COUNTIFS(tblApplications[Source_Clean],"LinkedIn",tblApplications[Stage],"Hired")

CHAT ONLY (new chat, different model):
Using tblApplications, count applications and hires (Stage = "Hired") by Source_Clean.
Show a table sorted by hires, highest first.
```

Step 6. Switch to Allow editing and build a review view, one change at a time. After each change, look at the sheet and keep it or select Undo in the Copilot pane. Finally ask Copilot how many rows the filter shows, then ask it to clear the filter so all 242 rows return.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
1) Highlight entire rows of tblApplications where Stage is "Hired" with a light green fill.
2) Sort tblApplications by Interview_Score from highest to lowest, then by Days_in_Pipeline
from lowest to highest.
3) Filter tblApplications to show only Client_Sector = "Technology" and Stage = "Interview".
4) How many rows of tblApplications are visible with this filter?
5) Clear all filters on tblApplications and confirm all 242 rows are visible.
```

Step 7. Prompt_Log already lists every prompt in this lab with its step and mode. Ask Copilot to fill in what it did, how it was verified and your decision (Keep, Revise or Undo). Save the workbook (Ctrl+S / Cmd+S) when it is done.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
LOG (Allow editing):
Prompt_Log already lists every prompt in this lab. For each one I ran, fill in What Copilot
did and How I verified, and set Decision to Keep. I will tell you any row to change to Revise
or Undo.
```

Sample Prompts

Use these prompts in the Copilot pane (or adapt them). Name the table and columns, state the output, and always verify the result. The same prompts are in sample-prompts.txt in this lab folder.

Copy-ready prompts online:
https://tertiarycourses.github.io/C34-Microsoft-365-Copilot-for-Excel/prompts/#lab-1

#	Purpose	Prompt
1	Describe	Describe tblApplications: what one row represents, each column's data type, the row count and the Applied_Date range. Do not change the workbook.

#	Purpose	Prompt
2	Data quality	List any Application_ID that appears more than once in tblApplications and any Source value that is not in the canonical list on About_This_Data.
3	Plan first	Plan how you would flag duplicate Application_IDs and standardise Source. Show me the steps before you change anything.
4	Clean helper column	Add a column Source_Clean that trims spaces from Source and replaces 'Linked In' with 'LinkedIn'. Do not change the original Source column.
5	Question	Using tblApplications, count applications and hires by Source_Clean and show the hire rate. Sort by hires, highest first.
6	Question	Which Client_Sector received the most applications, and how many? Show the count for every sector.
7	Highlight	Highlight rows where Stage is Hired in light green.
8	Sort	Sort tblApplications by Interview_Score from highest to lowest, then by Days_in_Pipeline from lowest to highest.
9	Filter	Filter to show only Technology applications at the Interview stage.
10	Insight	What's interesting about this pipeline data? Give three observations, each with the numbers behind it.

Test It

Check	Expected result
Rows in tblApplications	242 rows, 240 unique Application_IDs
Duplicate IDs (orange)	APP-0018 and APP-0020 - 4 orange cells: 2 near the top, 2 in the last rows
Fixed Source cells (yellow)	5 cells: 3 'Linked In' + 2 'JobStreet '
LinkedIn count in Source_Clean	69
Hires	22 in total; LinkedIn has the most (8)
Technology + Interview filter	9 rows; all 242 back after clearing it

Checkpoint

Keep this workbook in work-c34. Lab 2 uses a separate requisitions workbook, so a learner who is behind can start Lab 2 from its own data folder.

Troubleshooting

If this happens	Fix
The Copilot button is missing or greyed out.	Save the file as a normal .xlsx, close and reopen it, and update Excel. Check your licence in your Microsoft 365 account and ask IT if Copilot is disabled for your tenant. Pair with a neighbour meanwhile.
There is no Plan option in the mode menu.	Some Excel builds show only Allow editing and Chat only. Use Chat only, end the prompt with 'Show me the plan; do not change anything yet', then switch to Allow editing to carry it out.
'Unsupported file state' message.	Save as a normal .xlsx (Strict Open XML files are not supported), close and reopen it. If the file is read-only, copy it into work-c34 and open the copy.
Copilot answers about the whole sheet instead of the table.	Name the table (tblApplications) and the exact columns in the prompt, and click inside the table before asking.
Copilot's count differs from your formula.	Ask Copilot how it counted (rows vs unique IDs, which Stage values). Trust the formula, record the difference and refine the prompt.

Challenge

Ask Copilot to add a Pipeline_Status column that groups Stage into Active (Applied, Screening, Interview, Offer), Hired and Closed (Rejected, Withdrawn). Verify the three counts add up to the row count.

Reflection

Which data-quality issue would most distort a source-effectiveness report if you had not found it, and why?